

Assignment 4

Introduction to Linguistics 2

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Question 1:

Write a summary of "Meaning as a Weapon: A Pragmatic Analysis of Narcissistic Communication" by Paris B. Obdan in at least 1500 words.

The paper looks at the work of linguistic philosophers like Grice, Abbot, Stalnaker, Stokke etc. and uses their principles to analyse the behaviour of Narcissistic speakers.

It shows how they make the hearer lose touch with reality, and how the conversation turns into a battle, where presupposition, expressive meaning and plausible deniability are used to ensure that the hearer loses 'home ground' and that every 'match' is played on the speakers turf, i.e. that the conversation rules are dictated by the narcissist and the hearer has no option but to abide by them, simply due to the human tendency to avoid conflict.

Linguists assume that when we converse, co-operation between the speaker (S) and hearer (H) are to be expected. Even cases of lying, misleading, presupposition, and deniability typically examine pathologies of communication against this co-operative background. So, for us, co-operation becomes the rule, whilst deception is the exception.

But what if one party refuses to uphold this dynamic, and instead even weaponizes this predetermined notion of cooperation for weaponizing the conversation. This results in the other party single-handedly carrying the Gricean labour of both halves of the conversation.

What is this Gricean labour?

It's making sure that the conversation remains cooperative, and upholds the four Gricean maxims (which will be elaborated in Q2 : Quantity, Quality, Relation and Manner).

One of the major ways that narcissists weaponize meaning is by exploiting the implicit meaning that is rendered onto utterances by the context they're found in. This lends plausible deniability to the narcissist, allowing them to reiterate that they only meant the LITERAL meaning of the sentence.

It also prevents the hearer from going to a third party for help, as the sentence itself was innocuous.

For eg. if the narcissist says:

"Wow.. that's a great idea", but with a dry tone of sarcasm and contempt, the hearer is bound to feel insulted. But, the speaker has the full ability to deny that interpretation of their statement.

Narcissistic communication is thus " implicature-maximalist and accountability-minimalist", seeking to retroactively rewrite speaker meaning based on how it's perceived.

This can leave the hearer feeling destabilised and second guessing themselves, ("Is the speaker really being offensive or am I overreacting?").

Thus, a narcissist exploits the Stalnakerian framework to become the "de facto curator of the shared world of the conversation." Stalnaker's ideas rest on the beliefs that:

Every conversation is taken to a unique shared goal between the hearer and speaker, where every speech act is aimed at updating and being interpreted against a unique information set that is characterized in terms of a shared mental state between the speaker and the hearer

However, instead of negotiating this shared information set, a narcissist imposes it. The background the speaker projects onto the conversation is privately engineered, not collaboratively formed. Before entering the conversation, a narcissist performs extensive internal "world-building", constructing a distorted narrative that they then treat as the truth, simply because it preserves their superiority and innocence.

They insert presuppositions into the conversation, instead of making assertions. An assertion is more concrete (it can be debated against and rejected); but a presupposition makes it seem that the narcissist is simply referring to the speaker and hearer's shared understanding.

Hence, rejecting a presupposition requires a confrontation. Thus, the hearer usually abides by the very human need for coherence and conflict aversion and hence doesn't challenge these statements. Gradually, these presuppositions built atop each other in order to create a synthetic common ground, which gives the illusion of a jointly established history.

If the hearer does challenge the presupposition, it often reinforces what the narcissist says.

Refuting statements like "You never support me" or "Why are you always confrontative" only backs them up further.

Presuppositions thus lead to "real-time, future-oriented, and retroactive abuse", as the narcissist becomes the arbiter of what is real.

They function as planted mines: they return later as "established facts." and enable gaslighting of the victim, demanding that the victim rewrite their own memories for coherence, eroding their sense of continuity.

But why?

The author believes that though some narcissists reward compliance, many actively seek conflict, since provoking emotional chaos in the other person externalizes and stabilizes their own inner chaos.

Narcissists misread cooperative speakers as opponents or marks, overprojecting their manipulative reasoning onto others.

Hence, efforts by the victim to correct the common ground are seen as disrespectful power grabs.

So when a narcissist believes ("Everyone thinks like this"), communication as a narcissist becomes a structurally distinctive mode of meaning-making; "using implicature, presupposition, and contextual manipulation", in an adversarial manner.

So the need for presuppositions and the aversion to assertions becomes a psychological necessity for the narcissist.

“To assert is to be accountable. To be accountable is to be vulnerable. And vulnerability is existentially intolerable for the narcissistic self.”

Thus, the narcissist can mislead the hearer with maximum interpersonal leverage and epistemic cost. One of the ways to do so is to weaponize expressive meaning. Take the sentences:

“You’re late.” and “Great.... You’re late....again”.
These do not have the same connotation.

The speaker’s attitude thus adds another level of meaning to a sentence. Yet, this meaning cannot be concretely evaluated. Any attempts in confronting the speaker about the same can simply lead to them saying that “You’re just projecting”, which instantly shifts the blame and makes the hearer seem irrational. This allows the narcissist to:

1. **Attack without asserting:**

The narcissist exploits the gap between the sentence meaning (the actual semantics of the sentence spoken) and the speaker meaning (the expressive meaning lent to an utterance by virtue of the context it was spoken in, and the prosodic features used for the same). This gives the narcissist ample wiggle room to deny accusations and refuse accountability.

It also weakens the hearer's case against the speaker. If the hearer paraphrases what the speaker says to a third party, the connotations attached to the sentence cannot be conveyed. If the hearer informs a third party of what the speaker’s implied, the narcissist now has a chance to not only escape conviction, but also paint the hearer as the ‘unstable’ one: “I never meant that.”, “Why would you assume something like this?”, “Why are you always so defensive?”

This denies any implicature of the narcissist, as expressive content is almost impossible to quote back.

2. **Maintain plausible deniability:**

This builds upon the first point. “Since expressives are not truth-evaluable, the narcissist can hide behind literal meaning while still transmitting hostility.”

3. Project emotional dominance:

Narcissists view cooperative speakers as opponents, and the conversation as a battle to be won. The destabilisation of the hearer helps the narcissist calm their own inner chaos.

Hence, the narcissist exploits the suprasegmental features of language (tone, sighs, scoffs etc.) to signal a hierarchy, lowering the hearer’s status, while increasing their own.

4. Trigger the victim’s self-doubt:

As expressives encode attitude rather than propositional content, they injure the target’s sense of self, not their beliefs, making them especially corrosive in extended relationships.

Dinges and Zakkou researched the speaker’s deniability. They analyzed how the flexibility lent to language via pragmatics and context is weaponized by a narcissist.

There’s a difference between structurally impaired narcissists (who have a crude internal map and lie as their representational system is porous), who weaponize delusion, and the strategic narcissists who weaponize pragmatics.

When an utterance has multiple plausible interpretations, it lends the speaker a degree of freedom, allowing them to either commit to the perceived meaning of the utterance, or disown it, depending on the hearer’s reaction.

Thus, “Meaning is retrofitted to the interpersonal payoff”.

The advantage of this “liability space” extended to the speaker, is skewed against the hearer. Thus, the meaning of an utterance is used for opportunism, not information exchange.

But who is the most vulnerable to such exploitation by narcissists?

Autistic speakers.

For an autistic speaker, “Assertions are commitments, presuppositions are sincere, implicatures are cooperative bridges, and context is a shared resource.”

This communication style is semantically transparent, treating literal meaning as the foundation of a conversation. With this world-view, cooperation, sincerity, and mutual truth-seeking are assumed to be the baseline of linguistic exchange.

Hence, as autistic speakers don’t USE pragmatics for exploitation, they don't expect interpersonal exploitation to be hidden inside the same.

“In the autistic communicative ecology, the Cooperative Principle is not a heuristic - it is the default metaphysics of interaction”.

This creates an asymmetric advantage for the narcissist; they can exploit implicatures while the hearer simply defaults to truth-conditions. Manipulations by the narcissist now land cleanly; their implicatures are read cooperatively; their presuppositions are accepted without resistance, and the “autistic partner doesn’t activate the defensive interpretive filters that narcissistic discourse presupposes in its targets.”

Thus, narcissists often choose literal, honest, semantically oriented partners as they are easier to dominate. There may also be an evolutionary reason for the same.

“...A cooperative, truth-driven partner supplies relationship stability, attachment, routine, and predictability, components narcissists cannot generate internally. Meanwhile the narcissist supplies charisma, initiative, and external social navigation, components autistic speakers may struggle with.

The pairing is thus simultaneously adaptive at the reproductive level and maladaptive at the psychological level..”

Another thing narcissists understand clearly is that the true game of meaning is triadic:

The speaker -> the target -> the bystanders.

What the narcissist aims to do is:

1. Deliver the hit towards the target
2. Appear innocent and charming before the bystanders.
3. Preserve their own ego by maintaining the fiction of benevolence.

Narcissists often use code words or dog whistles (“utterances designed so that one audience hears something innocuous while another hears the real message”) for the same.

It allows the narcissist to form a temporary in-group of themselves and the bystanders, while the target is cast as the out-group.

The narcissist thus elevates themselves, aligns the audience, and isolates the victim.

A dog whistle like “Bless her heart! She gets so overwhelmed” allows the narcissist to dismiss and belittle the emotional and mental capacity of their partners, all while appearing gentle and affectionate.

All these pragmatic strategies,

“implicature-as-weapon, presupposition smuggling, deniability, interpretive latitude, expressive contempt, code words etc.”

don’t work in isolation. They slowly accumulate and gradually alter the epistemic environment of the victim.

Thus, “what emerges is not merely manipulation, but what can be called epistemic capture:

the gradual rewriting of a person’s interpretive world through asymmetric pragmatics.”

Hence, the pragmatics of conversation no longer remain neutral. They become a cognitive economy, which can be exploited by those who refuse to remain cooperative in communication.

Question 2:

Consider the 4 Gricean Maxims: Quality, Quantity, Relation and Manner. Explain with examples which kinds of FTAs (violating positive or negative face) could take place with the violation of each maxim.

The four Gricean Maxims are as follows:

1. Maxim of Quality:

This Maxim calls for truthfulness. It asks the communicating parties to only communicate what they KNOW to be true, and have sufficient evidence regarding the same.

The violation of this maxim can be used to threaten the positive face of both the speaker and the hearer.

Positive Face threat to Speaker:

Usage of sarcasm for self-deprecating humor is one of the ways S can harm their own positive face. “Wow.... I am way too smart”, after scoring poorly on a test.

Positive Face threat to Hearer:

Usage of sarcasm for insulting H is one of the ways S can harm the hearer's positive face. “Why yes Sherlock.. That IS a great idea”, shows that the speaker is obviously insulting the hearer, so the literal meaning of the sentence is obviously false.

These cases require the speaker to use irony or sarcasm to speak utterances they KNOW are not true. Hence, they are examples of the first maxim.

2. Maxim of Quantity:

This Maxim calls for informativeness. It means that the communicating party conveys only as much information as is needed; not more, not less.

Violation of this maxim can hurt the:

Positive face of the Hearer:

Being purposefully vague can lend a certain speaker meaning to the sentence. It can be something positive, like “Um...it was fine”, (said while blushing after a date), or something negative “Um...it was fine”, said with uncertainty and apathy after the same date. The first utterance is born of shyness, the second of disappointment.

Answering “What did you like about my presentation” with “Well...It was fine”, implies to H that there was little to be liked about the same.

On the contrary, exceedingly long utterances like explaining a simple task in great detail can also harm the positive face of the hearer, as it seems to assume that the hearer is incompetent.

Positive face of the Speaker:

Unnecessarily long utterances by the speaker also make them look confused, unprepared and incompetent. If S answers a simple “How is the weather” with a long and complicated weather analysis, they seem immature and impervious to social cues.

Negative face of the Hearer:

Those exceedingly long utterances can also harm the negative face of the hearer. Micromanaging by the speaker, and a list of

unnecessarily long instructions, infringes upon the autonomy and freedom of H.

3. Maxim of Relation:

This Maxim calls for relevance. It asks the communicating parties to convey ONLY what is relevant to the conversation.

Violation of this maxim can harm the:

Positive face of the Hearer:

A completely unrelated topic in the middle of a conversation is seen as a snub. If an acquaintance is accosting a group of friends with details of vacation they took, the group can abruptly change the topic, “Hey when is that new movie dropping?”. This shows a clear disregard for what the other party is saying.

But, this can be a double edged sword.

Positive face of the Speaker:

If in the above scenario, the group is also friends with the person telling the story, and is interested in hearing it, snubbing them is then seen as rude and a sign of poor manners and self importance on the speaker’s part. Hence, the speaker loses their positive face.

So what decides who loses face in such a scenario?

If there's a third party in the conversation, it depends on them. They can agree with the subject change (harming the positive face of the hearer), or steer the conversation back to the previous topic (harming the positive face of the speaker).

In the absence of a third party, social hierarchy, and who wishes more to speak with whom, is the deciding factor.

If an investor changes the topic in the middle of the pitch, the hearer loses face. If the person asking for an investment repeatedly

steers the topic back to the project they are working on, the speaker loses face, coming off as desperate and rude.

4. Maxim of Manner:

This Maxim calls for clarity. It asks the communicating parties to be brief and clear, and to avoid ambiguity and obscurity.

Violating this maxim can hurt the:

Positive face of the Hearer:

Similar to the violation of the maxim of quantity, being purposefully vague can lend a certain speaker meaning to the sentence, which can harm the hearer's positive face.

Saying "I have thoughts on your presentation", doesn't convey what exactly those thoughts are, but if said with a displeased expression, it harms the positive face of the hearer, with the implicit notion that the presentation was not liked.

Positive face of the Speaker:

Being unclear with your thoughts can create an impression of incompetence. Pitching a project idea with:

"Um.. so what I was saying was that... you know how ... like....", makes the listener assume that the speaker is uncertain and confused.

Question 3:

Consider the third party effect in "Humorous face-threatening acts: Humor as strategy" by Anat Zajdman. Which concept explained in "Meaning as a Weapon: A Pragmatic Analysis of Narcissistic Communication" by Paris B. Obdan is this most related to? Explain the similarities and differences.

The third party has an important role, not just in determining the efficiency of face threatening acts, but also in how meaning is weaponized by narcissists to 'win' a conversation.

Their impact is related to the concept of **Code Words, Dogwhistles, and the Narcissist's Two-Audience Problem.**

The similarities and differences of the role of the third party in both the above scenarios are as such.

Similarities:

Triadic structure of conversation:

The conversation now moves from having just the speaker and hearer, to having the speaker -> the hearer (the target) -> the bystanders (the third party). Thus, all subsequent conversation takes place keeping the presence of this bystander in mind.

How does this dynamic affect the conversation?

That depends on HOW the third party is inclined. Take the example of:

Lending deniability to the speaker:

If the third party is on the speaker's side, or is oblivious to the speaker meaning of a sentence, it leads to loss of accountability for the speaker. If the hearer objects at the speaker's sarcasm laced "Wow... that's a great idea", the bystander can wittingly or unwittingly side with S. "They were just complimenting you." S thus gains credibility, whilst simultaneously painting H as the unstable one.

Lending credibility to the hearer:

Assume the opposite case, i.e. the third party is on the hearer's side. In this case, H can object to the speaker's utterances with added vigor, as the third party lends more credibility to the hearer's arguments.

But how often do third parties help speakers as compared to hearers?

Lack of support for the hearer:

If the hearer is unsure of the third party's stance, they are likely to mitigate their reaction based on how the third party reacts to it. Though this also applies to the speaker, the speaker still has an asymmetric advantage:

The speaker never uses assertions, but objecting to the speaker requires assertions; and assertions lack deniability.

Hence, the hearer is more vulnerable to being judged and corrected by the third party.

So, as the third party is usually inclined to support S, the hearer cannot object to an utterance without making things worse for themselves.

The bystander is often unwilling of their compliance:

In most scenarios, the bystander is not malicious or poised against the hearer. They are simply unaware of their role in the conversation.

If the bystander backs the speaker ("They were just complimenting you"), or the hearer ("What you said seemed mean"), they are usually not actively thinking of their place in the conversation, not of the power their opinion holds in this triadic framework.

Differences:

Risk to the speaker:

As seen earlier, though the third party is more poised to side with S, they can also side with the hearer in cases. A person delivering an FTA is more at risk for this. The scope of deniability is lesser for an FTA, hence, it's quite possible that the third party sides with H.

But for narcissistic communication, the speaker meaning of a sentence is a lot more veiled. Hence, the risk to S is lower.

The reason for the third party's presence:

For an FTA, the third party's presence can be perfectly innocent. S doesn't necessarily need the bystander to deliver an FTA. But for a narcissist, the presence of a bystander is crucial and is often knowingly arranged to ensure the success of dogwhistles and the lack of accountability.

The effect of the third party's compliance:

For an FTA, the third party's agreement with S leads to H's loss of face. But for narcissistic communication, it leads to the loss of epistemic autonomy of the hearer.

In the same way each presupposition builds atop another, this long term agreement of third parties with S leads to the erosion of H's ability to rely on their own epistemic faculties, and is a targeted attack on the victim's standing as an epistemic agent.